

Chapter LI

A Passion



THE day of his arrival, on returning from the Palais Royal, Athos, as we have seen, went straight to his hotel in the Rue Saint-Honore. He there found the Vicomte de Bragelonne waiting for him in his chamber, chatting with Grimaud. It was not an easy thing to talk with this old servant. Two men only possessed the secret, Athos and D'Artagnan. The first succeeded, because Grimaud sought to make him speak himself; D'Artagnan, on the contrary, because he knew how to make Grimaud talk. Raoul was occupied in making him describe the voyage to England, and Grimaud had related it in all its details, with a limited number of gestures and eight words, neither more nor less. He had, at first, indicated by an undulating movement of his hand, that his master and he had crossed the sea. 'Upon some expedition?' Raoul had asked.

Grimaud by bending down his head had answered, 'Yes.'

'When monsieur le comte incurred much danger?' asked Raoul.

'Neither too much nor too little,' was replied by a shrug of the shoulders.

'But still, what sort of danger?' insisted Raoul.

Grimaud pointed to the sword, he pointed to the fire and to a musket that was hanging on the wall.

'Monsieur le comte had an enemy there, then?' cried Raoul.

'Monk,' replied Grimaud.

'It is strange,' continued Raoul, 'that monsieur le comte persists in considering me a novice, and not allowing me to partake the honour and danger of his adventure.'

Grimaud smiled. It was at this moment Athos came in. The host was lighting him up the stairs, and Grimaud, recognizing the step of his master,

hastened to meet him, which cut short the conversation. But Raoul was launched on the sea of interrogatories, and did not stop. Taking both hands of the comte, with warm, but respectful tenderness,—‘How is it, monsieur,’ said he, ‘that you have set out upon a dangerous voyage without bidding me adieu, without commanding the aid of my sword, of myself, who ought to be your support, now I have the strength; whom you have brought up like a man? Ah! monsieur, can you expose me to the cruel trial of never seeing you again?’

‘Who told you, Raoul,’ said the comte, placing his cloak and hat in the hands of Grimaud, who had unbuckled his sword, ‘who told you that my voyage was a dangerous one?’

‘I,’ said Grimaud.

‘And why did you do so?’ said Athos, sternly.

Grimaud was embarrassed; Raoul came to his assistance, by answering for him. ‘It is natural, monsieur, that our good Grimaud should tell me the truth in what concerns you. By whom should you be loved and supported, if not by me?’

Athos did not reply. He made a friendly motion to Grimaud, which sent him out of the room; he then seated himself in a fauteuil, whilst Raoul remained standing before him.

‘But it is true,’ continued Raoul, ‘that your voyage was an expedition, and that steel and fire threatened you?’

‘Say no more about that, vicomte,’ said Athos, mildly. ‘I set out hastily, it is true; but the service of King Charles II required a prompt departure. As to your anxiety, I thank you for it, and I know that I can depend on you. You have not wanted for anything, vicomte, in my absence, have you?’

‘No, monsieur, thank you.’

‘I left orders with Blaisois to pay you a hundred pistoles, if you should stand in need of money.’

‘Monsieur, I have not seen Blaisois.’

‘You have been without money, then?’

‘Monsieur, I had thirty pistoles left from the sale of the horses I took in my last campaign, and M. le Prince had the kindness to allow me to win two hundred pistoles at his play-table three months ago.’

‘Do you play? I don’t like that, Raoul.’

‘No,’ said he, ‘no; I see the whole scheme of that man. Belle-Isle belongs to M. Fouquet; Belle-Isle is being fortified: that is a conspiracy on the part of M. Fouquet. The discovery of that conspiracy is the ruin of the superintendent, and that discovery is the result of the correspondence with England: this is why Colbert wished to have that correspondence. Oh! but I cannot place all my dependence upon that man; he has a good head, but I must have an arm!’ Louis, all at once, uttered a joyful cry. ‘I had,’ said he, ‘a lieutenant of musketeers!’

‘Yes, sire—Monsieur d’Arragnan.’

‘He quitted the service for a time.’

‘Yes, sire.’

‘Let him be found, and be here to-morrow the first thing in the morning.’

The valet de chambre bowed and went out.

‘Thirteen millions in my cellar,’ said the king; ‘Colbert carrying my purse and D’Arragnan my sword—I am king.’

'Impossible, monsieur, for that correspondence is kept from the council; monsieur le cardinal himself carried it on.'

'I thought your majesty had this morning declared that there should no longer be a council?'

'Yes, I said so.'

'Let your majesty then have the goodness to read all the letters yourself, particularly those from England; I hold strongly to this article.'

'Monsieur, you shall have that correspondence, and render me an account of it.'

'Now, sire, what shall I do with respect to the finances?'

'Everything M. Fouquet has not done.'

'That is all I ask of your majesty. Thanks, sire, I depart in peace;' and at these words he took his leave. Louis watched his departure. Colbert was not yet a hundred paces from the Louvre when the king received a courier from England. After having looked at and examined the envelope, the king broke the seal precipitately, and found a letter from Charles II. The following is what the English prince wrote to his royal brother:—

'Your majesty must be rendered very uneasy by the illness of M. le Cardinal Mazarin; but the excess of danger can only prove of service to you. The cardinal is given over by his physician. I thank you for the gracious reply you have made to my communication touching the Princess Henrietta, my sister, and, in a week, the princess and her court will set out for Paris. It is gratifying to me to acknowledge the fraternal friendship you have evinced towards me, and to call you, more justly than ever, my brother. It is gratifying to me, above everything, to prove to your majesty how much I am interested in all that may please you. You are wrong in having Belle-Île-en-Mer secretly fortified. That is wrong. We shall never be at war against each other. That measure does not make me uneasy, it makes me sad. You are spending useless millions; tell your ministers so; and rest assured that I am well informed; render me the same service, my brother, if occasion offers.'

The king rang his bell violently, and his valet de chambre appeared. 'Monsieur Colbert is just gone; he cannot be far off. Let him be called back!' exclaimed he.

The valet was about to execute the order, when the king stopped him.

'I never play, monsieur; it was M. le Prince who ordered me to hold his cards at Chantilly—one night when a courier came to him from the king. I won, and M. le Prince commanded me to take the stakes.'

'Is that a practice in the household, Raoul?' asked Athos with a frown.

'Yes, monsieur; every week M. le Prince affords, upon one occasion or another, a similar advantage to one of his gentlemen. There are fifty gentlemen in his highness's household; it was my turn.'

'Very well! You went into Spain, then?'

'Yes, monsieur, I made a very delightful and interesting journey.'

'You have been back a month, have you not?'

'Yes, monsieur.'

'And in the course of that month?'

'In that month—'

'What have you done?'

'My duty, monsieur.'

'Have you not been home, to La Fère?'

Raoul coloured. Athos looked at him with a fixed but tranquil expression.

'You would be wrong not to believe me,' said Raoul. 'I feel that I coloured, and in spite of myself. The question you did me the honour to ask me is of a nature to raise in me much emotion. I colour, then, because I am agitated, not because I meditate a falsehood.'

'I know, Raoul, you never lie.'

'No, monsieur.'

'Besides, my young friend, you would be wrong; what I wanted to say—'

'I know quite well, monsieur. You would ask me if I have not been to Blois?'

'Exactly so.'

'I have not been there; I have not even seen the person to whom you allude.' Raoul's voice trembled as he pronounced these words. Athos, a sovereign judge in all matters of delicacy, immediately added, 'Raoul, you answer me with a painful feeling; you are unhappy.'

'Very, monsieur; you have forbidden me to go to Blois, or to see Mademoiselle de la Vallière again.' Here the young man stopped. That dear name, so delightful to pronounce, made his heart bleed, although so sweet upon his lips.

'And I have acted rightly, Raoul.' Athos hastened to reply. 'I am neither an unjust nor a barbarous father; I respect true love; but I look forward for you to a future—an immense future. A new reign is about to break upon us like a fresh dawn. War calls upon a young king full of chivalric spirit. What is wanting to assist this heroic ardour is a battalion of young and free lieutenants who would rush to the fight with enthusiasm, and fall, crying: "Vive le Roi!" instead of "Adieu, my dear wife." You understand that, Raoul. However brutal my reasoning may appear, I conjure you, then, to believe me, and to turn away your thoughts from those early days of youth in which you took up this habit of love—days of effeminate carelessness, which soften the heart and render it incapable of consuming those strong bitter draughts called glory and adversity. Therefore, Raoul, I repeat to you, you should see in my counsel only the desire of being useful to you, only the ambition of seeing you prosper. I believe you capable of becoming a remarkable man. March alone, and you will march better, and more quickly.'

'You have commanded, monsieur,' replied Raoul, 'and I obey.'

'Commanded!' cried Athos. 'Is it thus you reply to me? I have commanded you! Oh! you distort my words as you misconceive my intentions. I do not command you; I request you.'

'No, monsieur, you have commanded,' said Raoul, persistently; 'had you requested me, your request is even more effective than your order. I have not seen Mademoiselle de la Vallière again.'

'But you are unhappy! you are unhappy!' insisted Athos.

Raoul made no reply.

'I find you pale; I find you dull. The sentiment is strong, then?'

'It is a passion,' replied Raoul.

'No—a habit.'

'Monsieur, you know I have traveled much, that I have passed two years far away from her. A habit would yield to an absence of two years, I believe; whereas, on my return, I loved not more, that was impossible, but as much. Mademoiselle de la Vallière is for me the one lady above all others; but you are for me a god upon earth—to you I sacrifice everything.'

'You are wrong,' said Athos; 'I have no longer any right over you. Age has emancipated you; you no longer even stand in need of my consent. Besides, I

'I wish your majesty to allow me assistance in the labours of the office of intendant.'

'That post would lose its value.'

'It would gain in security.'

'Choose your colleagues.'

'Messieurs Breteuil, Marin, Hervart.'

'To-morrow the ordonnance shall appear.'

'Sire, I thank you.'

'Is that all you ask?'

'No, sire, one thing more.'

'What is that?'

'Allow me to compose a chamber of justice.'

'What would this chamber of justice do?'

'Try the farmers-general and contractors, who, during ten years, have been robbing the state.'

'Well, but what would you do with them?'

'Hang two or three, and that would make the rest disgorge.'

'I cannot commence my reign with executions, Monsieur Colbert.'

'On the contrary, sire, you had better, in order not to have to end with them.'

'The king made no reply. "Does your majesty consent?" said Colbert.

'I will reflect upon it, monsieur.'

'It will be too late when reflection may be made.'

'Why?'

'Because you have to deal with people stronger than ourselves, if they are warned.'

'Compose that chamber of justice, monsieur.'

'I will, sire.'

'Is that all?'

'No, sire; there is still another important affair. What rights does your majesty attach to this office of intendant?'

'Well—I do not know—the customary ones.'

'Sire, I desire that this office be invested with the right of reading the correspondence with England.'

arch, then of another, then of a third; after which the gate grated upon its hinges to be closed. Soon after, somebody scratched with his nail at the door of the cabinet. The king opened it himself, and beheld Colbert, whose first word was this:—‘The money is in your majesty’s cellar.’

The king then descended and went himself to see the barrels of specie, in gold and silver, which, under the direction of Colbert, four men had just rolled into a cellar of which the king had given Colbert the key in the morning. This review completed, Louis returned to his apartments, followed by Colbert, who had not apparently warmed with one ray of personal satisfaction.

‘Monsieur,’ said the king, ‘what do you wish that I should give you, as a recompense for this devotedness and probity?’

‘Absolutely nothing, sire.’

‘How! nothing? Not even an opportunity of serving me?’

‘If your majesty were not to furnish me with that opportunity, I should not the less serve you. It is impossible for me not to be the best servant of the king.’

‘You shall be intendant of the finances, M. Colbert.’

‘But there is already a superintendent, sire.’

‘I know that.’

‘Sire, the superintendent of the finances is the most powerful man in the kingdom.’

‘Ah!’ cried Louis, colouring, ‘do you think so?’

‘He will crush me in a week, sire. Your majesty gives me a contrôle for which strength is indispensable. An intendant under a superintendent,—that is inferiority.’

‘You want support—you do not reckon upon me?’

‘I had the honour of telling your majesty, that during the lifetime of M. de Mazarin, M. Fouquet was the second man in the kingdom; now M. de Mazarin is dead, M. Fouquet is become the first.’

‘Monsieur, I agree to what you told me of all things up to to-day; but to-morrow, please to remember, I shall no longer suffer it.’

‘Then I shall be of no use to your majesty?’

‘You are already, since you fear to compromise yourself in serving me.’

‘I only fear to be placed so that I cannot serve your majesty.’

‘What do you wish, then?’

will not refuse my consent after what you have told me. Marry Mademoiselle de la Vallière, if you like.’

Raoul was startled, but suddenly: ‘You are very kind, monsieur,’ said he; ‘and your concession excites my warmest gratitude, but I will not accept it.’

‘Then you now refuse?’

‘Yes, monsieur.’

‘I will not oppose you in anything, Raoul!’

‘But you have at the bottom of your heart an idea against this marriage: it is not your choice.’

‘That is true.’

‘That is sufficient to make me resist: I will wait.’

‘Beware, Raoul! What you are now saying is serious.’

‘I know it is, monsieur; as I said, I will wait.’

‘Until I die?’ said Athos, much agitated.

‘Oh! monsieur,’ cried Raoul, with tears in his eyes, ‘is it possible that you should wound my heart thus? I have never given you cause of complaint!’

‘Dear boy, that is true,’ murmured Athos, pressing his lips violently together to conceal the emotion of which he was no longer master. ‘No, I will no longer afflict you; only I do not comprehend what you mean by waiting. Will you wait till you love no longer?’

‘Ah! for that!—no, monsieur. I will wait till you change your opinion.’

‘I should wish to put the matter to a test, Raoul; I should like to see if Mademoiselle de la Vallière will wait as you do.’

‘I hope so, monsieur.’

‘But, take care, Raoul! suppose she did not wait? Ah, you are young, so confiding, so loyal! Women are changeable.’

‘You have never spoken ill to me of women, monsieur; you have never had to complain of them; why should you doubt of Mademoiselle de la Vallière?’

‘That is true,’ said Athos, casting down his eyes; ‘I have never spoken ill to you of women; I have never had to complain of them; Mademoiselle de la Vallière never gave birth to a suspicion; but when we are looking forward, we must go even to exceptions, even to improbabilities! If, I say, Mademoiselle de la Vallière should not wait for you?’

‘How, monsieur?’

‘If she turned her eyes another way.’

'If she looked favourably upon another, do you mean, monsieur?' said Raoul, pale with agony.

'Exactly.'

'Well, monsieur, I would kill him,' said Raoul, simply, 'and all the men whom Mademoiselle de la Vallière should choose, until one of them had killed me, or Mademoiselle de la Vallière had restored me her heart.'

Athos started. 'I thought,' resumed he, in an agitated voice, 'that you called my just now your god, your law in this world.'

'Oh!' said Raoul, trembling, 'you would forbid me the duel?'

'Suppose I did forbid it, Raoul?'

'You would not forbid me to hope, monsieur; consequently you would not forbid me to die.'

Athos raised his eyes toward the vicomte. He had pronounced these words with the most melancholy look. 'Enough,' said Athos, after a long silence, 'enough of this subject, upon which we both go too far. Live as well as you are able, Raoul, perform your duties, love Mademoiselle de la Vallière; in a word, act like a man, since you have attained the age of a man; only do not forget that I love you tenderly, and that you profess to love me.'

'Ah! monsieur le comte!' cried Raoul, pressing the hand of Athos to his heart.

'Enough, dear boy, leave me; I want rest. A propos, M. d'Artagnan has returned from England with me; you owe him a visit.'

'I will pay it, monsieur, with great pleasure. I love Monsieur d'Artagnan exceedingly.'

'You are right in doing so; he is a worthy man and a brave cavalier.'

'Who loves you dearly.'

'I am sure of that. Do you know his address?'

'At the Louvre, I suppose, or wherever the king is. Does he not command the musketeers?'

'No; at present M. d'Artagnan is absent on leave; he is resting for awhile. Do not, therefore, seek him at the posts of his service. You will hear of him at the house of a certain Planchet.'

'His former lackey?'

'Exactly; turned grocer.'

'I know; Rue des Lombards?'

Chapter I

The First Day of the Royalty of Louis XIV



IN the morning, the news of the death of the cardinal was spread through the castle, and thence speedily reached the city. The ministers Fouquet, Lyonne, and Letellier entered la salle des seances, to hold a council. The king sent for them immediately. 'Messieurs,' said he, 'as long as monsieur le cardinal lived, I allowed him to govern my affairs; but now I mean to govern them myself. You will give me your advice when I ask it. You may go.'

The ministers looked at each other with surprise. If they concealed a smile it was with a great effort, for they knew that the prince, brought up in absolute ignorance of business, by this took upon himself a burden much too heavy for his strength. Fouquet took leave of his colleagues upon the stairs, saying:—'Messieurs! there will be so much the less labour for us.'

And he gayly climbed into his carriage. The others, a little uneasy at the turn things had taken, went back to Paris together. Towards ten o'clock the king repaired to the apartment of his mother, with whom he had a long and private conversation. After dinner, he got into his carriage, and went straight to the Louvre. There he received much company, and took a degree of pleasure in remarking the hesitation of each, and the curiosity of all. Towards evening he ordered the doors of the Louvre to be closed, with the exception of only one, which opened on the quay. He placed on duty at this point two hundred Swiss, who did not speak a word of French, with orders to admit all who carried packages, but no others; and by no means to allow any one to go out. At eleven o'clock precisely, he heard the rolling of a heavy carriage under the

'In coined gold, sire.'

'That is well.'

'Where shall I send it?'

'To the Louvre. Thank you, M. Colbert.'

Colbert bowed and retired. 'Thirteen millions!' exclaimed Louis, as soon as he was alone. 'This must be a dream!' Then he allowed his head to sink between his hands, as if he were really asleep. But, at the end of a moment, he awoke, and opening the window violently, he bathed his burning brow in the keen morning air, which brought to his senses the scent of the trees, and the perfume of the flowers. A splendid dawn was gilding the horizon, and the first rays of the sun bathed in flame the young king's brow. 'This is the dawn of my reign,' murmured Louis XIV. 'It's a presage sent by the Almighty.'

'Somewhere thereabouts, or Rue des Arcis.'

'I will find it, monsieur—I will find it.'

'You will say a thousand kind things to him, on my part, and ask him to come and dine with me before I set out for La Fère.'

'Yes, monsieur.'

'Good-night, Raoul!'

'Monsieur, I see you wear an order I never saw you wear before; accept my compliments.'

'The Fleece!—that is true. A bauble, my boy, which no longer amuses an old child like myself. Good-night, Raoul!'

'I have a duplicate of it, signed by his hand.'

'A duplicate?'

'Yes, sire, and here it is.' Colbert drew the deed quietly from his pocket, and showed it to the king. The king read the article relative to the donation of the house.

'But,' said he, 'there is no question here but of the house; there is nothing said of the money.'

'Your pardon, sire, it is in my conscience.'

'And Monsieur Mazarin has intrusted it to you?'

'Why not, sire?'

'He! a man mistrustful of everybody?'

'He was not so of me, sire, as your majesty may perceive.'

Louis fixed his eyes with admiration upon that vulgar but expressive face.

'You are an honest man, M. Colbert,' said the king.

'That is not a virtue, it is a duty,' replied Colbert, coolly.

'But,' added Louis, 'does not the money belong to the family?'

'If this money belonged to the family it would be disposed of in the testament, as the rest of the fortune is. If this money belonged to the family, I, who drew up the deed of donation in favour of your majesty, should have added the sum of thirteen millions to that of forty millions which was offered to you.'

'How?' exclaimed Louis XIV, 'was it you who drew up the deed of donation?'

'Yes, sire.'

'And yet the cardinal was attached to you?' added the king, ingenuously.

'I had assured his eminence you would by no means accept the gift,' said Colbert, in that same quiet manner we have described, and which, even in the common habits of life, had something solemn in it.

Louis passed his hand over his brow: 'Oh! how young I am,' murmured he, 'to have command of men.'

Colbert waited the end of this monologue. He saw Louis raise his head. 'At what hour shall I send the money to your majesty?' asked he.

'To-night, at eleven o'clock; I desire that no one may know that I possess this money.'

Colbert made no more reply than if the thing had not been said to him.

'Is the amount in ingots, or coined gold?'

Louis, very much agitated, walked about, still frowning. 'But, if this is as you say, Monsieur Colbert,' said he, stopping all at once, 'I shall be ruined before I begin to reign.'

'You are, in fact, sire,' said the impassible caster-up of figures.

'Well, but yet, monsieur, the money is somewhere?'

'Yes, sire, and even as a beginning, I bring your majesty a note of funds which M. le Cardinal Mazarin was not willing to set down in his testament, neither in any act whatever, but which he confided to me.'

'To you?'

'Yes, sire, with an injunction to remit it to your majesty.'

'What! besides the forty millions of the testament?'

'Yes, sire.'

'M. de Mazarin had still other funds?'

Colbert bowed.

'Why, that man was a gulf!' murmured the king. 'M. de Mazarin on one side, M. Fouquet on the other,—more than a hundred millions perhaps between them! No wonder my coffers should be empty!' Colbert waited without stirring.

'And is the sum you bring me worth the trouble?' asked the king.

'Yes, sire, it is a round sum.'

'Amounting to how much?'

'To thirteen millions of livres, sire.'

'Thirteen millions!' cried Louis, trembling with joy; 'do you say thirteen millions, Monsieur Colbert?'

'I said thirteen millions, yes, your majesty.'

'Of which everybody is ignorant?'

'Of which everybody is ignorant.'

'Which are in your hands?'

'In my hands, yes, sire.'

'And which I can have?'

'Within two hours, sire.'

'But where are they, then?'

'In the cellar of a house which the cardinal possessed in the city, and which he was so kind as to leave me by a particular clause of his will.'

'You are acquainted with the cardinal's will, then?'

Chapter III

D'Artagnan's Lesson



AOUL did not meet with D'Artagnan the next day, as he had hoped. He only met with Planchet, whose joy was great at seeing the young man again, and who contrived to pay him two or three little soldierly compliments, savouring very little of the grocer's shop. But as Raoul was returning the next day from Vincennes at the head of fifty dragons confided to him by Monsieur le Prince, he perceived, in La Place Baudoyer, a man with his nose in the air, examining a house as we examine a horse we have a fancy to buy. This man, dressed in a citizen costume buttoned up like a military pourpoint, a very small hat on his head, but a long shagreen-mounted sword by his side, turned his head as soon as he heard the steps of the horses, and left off looking at the house to look at the dragons. It was simply M. d'Artagnan; D'Artagnan on foot; D'Artagnan with his hands behind him, passing a little review upon the dragons, after having reviewed the buildings. Not a man, not a tag, not a horse's hoof escaped his inspection. Raoul rode at the side of his troop; D'Artagnan perceived him the last. 'Eh!' said he, 'Eh! Mordieux!'

'I was not mistaken!' cried Raoul, turning his horse towards him.

'Mistaken—no! Good-day to you,' replied the ex-musketeer; whilst Raoul eagerly pressed the hand of his old friend. 'Take care, Raoul,' said D'Artagnan, 'the second horse of the fifth rank will lose a shoe before he gets to the Pont Marie; he has only two nails left in his off fore-foot.'

'Wait a minute, I will come back,' said Raoul.

'Can you quit your detachment?'

'The corner is there to take my place.'

'Then you will come and dine with me?'

'Most willingly, Monsieur d'Arragnan.'

'Be quick, then; leave your horse, or make them give me one.'

'I prefer coming back on foot with you.'

Raoul hastened to give notice to the cornet, who took his post; he then dismounted, gave his horse to one of the dragoons, and with great delight seized the arm of M. d'Arragnan, who had watched him during all these little evolutions with the satisfaction of a connoisseur.

'What, do you come from Vincennes?' said he.

'Yes, monsieur le chevalier.'

'And the cardinal?'

'Is very ill; it is even reported he is dead.'

'Are you on good terms with M. Fouquet?' asked D'Arragnan, with a disdainful movement of the shoulders, proving that the death of Mazarin did not affect him beyond measure.

'With M. Fouquet?' said Raoul; 'I do not know him.'

'So much the worse! so much the worse! for a new king always seeks to get good men in his employment.'

'Oh! the king means no harm,' replied the young man.

'I say nothing about the crown,' cried D'Arragnan; 'I am speaking of the king—the king, that is M. Fouquet, if the cardinal is dead. You must contrive to stand well with M. Fouquet, if you do not wish to molder away all your life as I have moldered. It is true you have, fortunately, other protectors.'

'M. le Prince, for instance.'

'Worn out! worn out!'

'M. le Comte de la Fère?'

'Athos! Oh! that's different; yes, Athos—and if you have any wish to make your way in England, you cannot apply to a better person; I can even say, without too much vanity, that I myself have some credit at the court of Charles II. There is a king—God speed him!'

'Ah!' cried Raoul, with the natural curiosity of well-born young people, while listening to experience and courage.

'Yes, a king who amuses himself, it is true, but who has had a sword in his hand, and can appreciate useful men. Athos is on good terms with Charles II. Take service there, and leave these scoundrels of contractors and farmers-general, who steal as well with French hands as others have done with Italian

'No, sire.'

'Upon this year, perhaps, I understand that; but upon next year?'

'Next year is eaten as bare as the current year.'

'But the year after, then?'

'Will be just like next year.'

'What do you tell me, Monsieur Colbert?'

'I say there are four years engaged beforehand.'

'They must have a loan, then.'

'They must have three, sire.'

'I will create offices to make them resign, and the salary of the posts shall be paid into the treasury.'

'Impossible, sire, for there have already been creations upon creations of offices, the provisions of which are given in blank, so that the purchasers enjoy them without filling them. That is why your majesty cannot make them resign. Further, upon each agreement M. Fouquet has made an abatement of a third, so that the people have been plundered, without your majesty profiting by it.'

The king started. 'Explain me that, M. Colbert,' he said.

'Let your majesty set down clearly your thought, and tell me what you wish me to explain.'

'You are right, clearness is what you wish, is it not?'

'Yes, sire, clearness. God is God above all things, because He made light.'

'Well, for example,' resumed Louis XIV, 'if to-day, the cardinal being dead, and I being king, suppose I wanted money?'

'Your majesty would not have any.'

'Oh! that is strange, monsieur! How! my superintendent would not find me any money?'

Colbert shook his large head.

'How is that?' said the king; 'is the income of the state so much in debt that there is no longer any revenue?'

'Yes, sire.'

The king frowned and said, 'If it be so, I will get together the ordonnances to obtain a discharge from the holders, a liquidation at a cheap rate.'

'Impossible, for the ordonnances have been converted into bills, which bills, for the convenience of return and facility of transaction, are divided into so many parts that the originals can no longer be recognized.'